Two Leaders, Hindutva and a New BJP Caste Coalition: The Ananth Kumar–Yediyurappa Era

Until the late 1980s, the BJP, and the Jan Sangh before it, had no stable social base in Karnataka. 'Big people come to a party when there is a base,' said Lehar Singh. 'Dedicated karyakartas were always there, but what can they do beyond a point without social leaders?' This changed in the 1990s, under the twin leadership of former RSS pracharaks Yediyurappa and Ananth Kumar, who forged a new social combination, expanding into new geographies. Yediyurappa is a Lingayat[88] from KR Pet in Mandya. He had, in fact, been named after the presiding deity of a twelfth-century Shaivite temple in Tumkur. The late Ananth Kumar, a Brahmin from Hubli, was a lawyer who practised in the Karnataka High Court.[89]

Yediyurappa initially made inroads as a farmer leader in this region, earning the sobriquet 'Raitha Nayaka' (Farmer Leader).[90] He first came into the 'limelight after he undertook a padayatra of bonded labourers from Shikaripur to Shimoga in 1981'. Two years later, in 1983, he was one of the BJP's first eighteen MLAs in Karnataka.[91] After Veerendra Patil's sacking in 1990, Yediyurappa became the fulcrum of Lingayat mobilisation. 'Lingayats are in large numbers in at least ten–twelve districts and in eighty to ninety assembly seats and ten–twelve Lok Sabha seats,' Anand explained, adding:[92]

When they shifted towards BJP, the whole game changed. After Veerendra Patil was sacked, within two–three years, the whole scenario changed. They [Congress] still haven't recovered from that … It is because of this leadership that the growth of the BJP in Karnataka was bigger than in any other than any state in South India. Yediyurappa expanded the party, brought in a committed group of Lingayats and we grew because of his leadership in north and central Karnataka. We moved from being four to forty to seventy-ninety to 110 in the state assembly because we expanded into new areas. Similarly, credit has to be given to Ananth Kumar. We have won Bangalore South so many times that